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Unity or commitment: A generational view of innovation in family firms

Angel L. Meroño-Cerdán

Facultad Economia y Empresa, Campus de Espinardo, Universidad de Murcia, Murcia, Spain

Correspondence
Angel L Meroño-Cerdán, Facultad Economia y Empresa, Campus de Espinardo, Universidad de Murcia, Murcia 30100, Spain.
Email: angelmer@um.es

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Abstract
Taking a qualitative approach, this study aims to identify the effects of family involvement on firms' innovation decisions and examine how this relationship is affected by the presence or absence of firm founders. Content analysis facilitates building a map to identify two modes of family influence on business and innovation: the business-first and family-first modes. In the former, commitment and long-term orientation encourage innovation as the principal means of survival, especially when the founder is no longer present. In the latter, unity constrains innovation, most commonly in firms led by a present founder. In contrast to the tenets of the socioemotional wealth approach, a first-generation family firm may suffer from myopia when family interests prevail over the firm's interests, even when business continuity is at stake.

KEYWORDS
commitment, content analysis, founder, innovation, long-term orientation, unity

INTRODUCTION

Innovation in business is essential to competing, surviving and succeeding in the family-firm continuity (Diaz-Moriana et al., 2020; Jaskiewicz, Combs, & Rau, 2015; Zellweger, Nason, & Nordqvist, 2012). Family firms can often appear less innovative than their counterparts (Sharma & Salvato, 2011; Zahra, 2005); nonetheless, various studies find that their innovation efforts achieve greater effectiveness (Duran et al., 2015; Matzler et al., 2015; Meroño-Cerdán, López-Nicolás, & Molina-Castillo, 2018). Family firms take longer to decide to innovate, but after the decision is made, they are faster (König, Kammerlander, & Enders, 2013).

Studies are increasingly addressing the distinct characteristics and effects of family involvement on innovation decisions (De Massis, Frattini, & Lichtenthaler, 2013). Chrisman et al. (2015) propose the 'Ability and Willingness Paradox' to explain innovation in family firms. Other works (De Massis, Minin, & Frattini, 2015; Röd, 2016) acknowledge greater ability to innovate alongside greater variability, due to socioemotional concerns that govern family firms' willingness to innovate. Socioemotional wealth (SEW) is a term defined by Gomez-Mejía et al. (2007) that refers to the nonfinancial aspects or affective endowments of family business owners. According to the socioemotional wealth approach, gains or losses in SEW represent the pivotal frame of reference that family-controlled firms use to make major strategic choices and policy decisions (Berrone, Cruz, & Gomez-Mejia, 2012). To preserve their SEW, families will make decisions not driven by economic but by socioemotional logic.

Innovation decisions usually imply an increase of business risk. Although innovation can assure continuity, growth and wealth generation, it can also threaten SEW. In situations of vulnerability (i.e., performance below aspirations), SEW and economic objectives are aligned, activating SEW as a catalyst for change. Alternately, in times of prosperity (i.e., performance above aspirations), SEW constitutes an impediment (Gomez-Mejia, Patel, & Zellweger, 2015). Therefore, although innovation is critical for survival, depending on the level of performance related to aspirations, the desire to preserve SEW can push or hinder innovativeness. Consequently, studying the influence of family involvement on innovation is

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linked to the importance of preserving socioemotional wealth. In this regard, SEW implicitly highlights family firm heterogeneity (Rau, Schneider-Siebke, & Günther, 2019). De Massis, Wang, & Chua (2019) delimit goals, governance and resources as the most important sources of heterogeneity in family firms, thereby explaining differences in attitudes and behaviours regarding innovation. Family owners' preference for non-economic goals will play a key role in innovation decisions, as well as stages of growth and transition. This study responds to Cesaroni, Chamochumbi Diaz, & Sentuti's (2021) call to investigate the heterogeneity of family firms and identify factors explaining why some are innovation-oriented and others are not.

Diverse studies show that the generation in charge of the firm may alter the importance of SEW (Stockmans, Lybaert, & Voordeckers, 2010). Some existing research into the subject considers such topics as boards (Le Breton-Miller & Miller, 2013), entrepreneurial orientation (Cruz & Nordqvist, 2012), profitability (Sciascia, Mazzola, & Kellermanns, 2014), long-term orientation (Diaz-Moriana et al., 2020), knowledge management (Memili, Fang, & Welsh, 2015b) and strategic planning (Eddleston et al., 2013). However, innovation has not yet been thoroughly analysed through a generational lens as a possible source of SEW heterogeneity. For that reason, this research focuses on the variable of generational stage as an element of SEW heterogeneity key in understanding innovative behaviours.

Ultimately, the prevalence of family interests over firm objectives, or vice versa, may affect innovation in family firms. At the same time, the generation in charge may alter this equilibrium. Many authors report that first-generation firms consider family objectives more important than business objectives; as successive generations enter the firm, the focus shifts from family objectives to a combination of family and business objectives (Davis & Harveston, 1999; Ensley & Pearson, 2005; Stockmans, Lybaert, & Voordeckers, 2010). Accordingly, first generations can be expected to afford greater importance to SEW than later generations. Nevertheless, more recent research finds first-generation family firms more prone to innovation (Beck et al., 2011), commitment (Le Breton-Miller & Miller, 2013) and entrepreneurship (Cruz & Nordqvist, 2012). These mixed results reveal a lack of understanding about the real influence of SEW on innovation as it relates to the generational stage of a family firm. Therefore, this study asks the questions: How does family involvement in the firm influence innovation decisions? How is that relationship be affected by the firm founder's presence or absence? Shedding light on these issues should help to explain the mechanisms alternately burdening or triggering innovation in family firms, depending on the generation in charge.

Classic studies of innovation in family firms follow a quantitative approach, with certain objective measures recurring frequently (e.g., finances, patents, R&D expenditures). This study takes a qualitative approach, mainly due to the rich context in which family firms are embedded. In fact, context is vital to understanding and reconciling existing findings from quantitative studies (Fletcher, Massis, & Nordqvist, 2016; Van Burg et al., 2022). Complex, idiosyncratic behaviours arise from the influence of different factors, including emotions, paradoxes and multiple goal dimensions (Kammerlander & De Massis, 2020). For each firm studied, two open-ended questions were asked, which concern the influence of family involvement on the firm and specifically on innovation. Eight personal interviews were conducted with Spanish CEOs.

Spanish firms were selected for three reasons. First, family firms are prevalent in the Spanish economy. Casillas et al. (2015) report that family firms, which comprise 90% of private firms, employ 85% of the private workforce. Second, the Spanish economy is in the domain of the OECD. Spanish gross domestic product (GDP) per capita in 2021 ranked 23 among the 38 OECD countries (OECD, 2021). Finally, the researcher's proximity to Spanish companies allows for a deeper understanding of the research objectives, which is particularly important when using qualitative methods. In this study, content analysis led to the emergence of different patterns in family firms. Differences according to the founder's presence—a proxy for 'first-generation' leadership—also emerged. Grounded in the tenets of SEW, this study uncovers the effect of family involvement on innovation by considering the effects of the founder's presence.

The finding of higher prioritisation of SEW in first-generation family firms—even at the cost of innovation and continuity—can help refine extant theory by considering the generation in charge. Two innovation patterns are found: business-first (i.e., commitment and a transgenerational view predominate) and family-first (i.e., the importance of unity and the weight of tradition predominate). Low levels of ability (e.g., scarce resources and capabilities) in family firms run by the founder should lead to willingness to innovate to ensure continuity. Therefore, SEW would act as a catalyst for innovation. Unexpectedly, the results reveal the predominance of a family-first innovation pattern in first-generation family firms, driving family interests to prevail over firm challenges. In this case, unity and the weight of tradition limit the family firm's continuity. Prioritising unity and tradition above commitment is a short-term approach that may end with the family firm. In this study, the founder's presence reveals that SEW may act as an impediment even when the business project is at stake, a situation labelled 'family myopia'. First-generation family firms are heavily dependent on the figure of the founder. Last stages of their presence at the forefront of the firm usually are characterised by different goals and expectations of the family members. In this situation, preserving SEW may prevail over business needs; in this vein, explaining

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heterogeneity derived from SEW and generation and how it influences innovation in family firms.

THEORETICAL BACKGROUND

Family influence on family firm innovation

Family involvement distinguishes family firms from other firms (Chrisman et al., 2012). This peculiarity of family firms, called 'familiness', is the set of resources and capabilities deriving from interactions between the family and the business (Habbershon & Williams, 1999; Habbershon, Williams, & MacMillan, 2003). Familiness has positive and negative effects (Irava & Moores, 2010); the family dimension can pose such clear advantages as long-term vision, commitment and family capital, but there are disadvantages, such as nepotism, internal conflict and insufficiency of qualifications (Sciascia & Mazzola, 2008).

In the last decade, the socioemotional wealth (SEW) approach was proposed to provide an understanding of the family's influence in the firm through the pursuit of noneconomic objectives (Gomez-Mejía et al., 2007). SEW preservation explains the decision-making in family firms, which sometimes occurs at the expense of financial wealth (Chrisman et al., 2012). Although socioemotional wealth is the 'higher-order' reference point, this may vary depending on external threats (Berrone, Cruz, & Gomez-Mejia, 2012). When performance exceeds aspirations, essentially risk-averse family firms prefer reliability (Patel & Chrisman, 2014). However, should performance fall below expectations, family firms may become more risk-seeking. Using performance improvement as a reference point leads family firms to deploy their unique resources, thus increasing their venture risk to protect their socioemotional wealth.

Innovation concerns generating, adopting and implementing new ideas, processes, products or services (Thompson, 1965). The way an organisation handles innovation has proven critical for achieving competitive advantages and high performance (Jaskiewicz, Combs, & Rau, 2015; Zellweger, Nason, & Nordqvist, 2012). Innovation management is drawing increasing interest in the field of family firms (Chrisman et al., 2012; De Massis, Frattini, & Lichtenthaler, 2013; Patel & Chrisman, 2014; Sanchez-Famoso, Maseda, & Iturralde, 2014). Recent works find differences between the ways that family and nonfamily firms manage innovation (e.g., Classen et al., 2014; De Massis, Frattini, & Lichtenthaler, 2013; Schepers et al., 2014). Most existing research focuses on evaluating evidence supporting a higher or lower level of family-firm innovativeness, with inconclusive findings (Craig, Dibrell, & Garrett, 2014; Matzler et al., 2015).

Several studies corroborate the notion that family firms tend to obtain better outcomes, although family firms appear to be less innovative. König, Kammerlander, & Enders's (2013) literature review indicates that incumbent family firms take longer to recognize discontinuous technologies, compared to nonfamily firms, but are quicker to implement them. In a meta-analysis of studies in 1981–2012 period carried out by Duran et al. (2015), family firms were found to invest less in innovation but have an increased conversion rate of innovation input into output and, ultimately, a higher innovation output than nonfamily firms. Nieto, Santamaria, & Fernandez's (2015) analysis of Spanish manufacturing from 1998 to 2007 also found that family firms perform fewer innovation efforts than nonfamily firms. Still, they are innovative, but only in line with their risk preference and resource endowment. Similarly, Matzler et al. (2015), using a data set of large German publicly traded firms between 2000 and 2009, found that family participation in management and governance impacts innovation input negatively and innovation output positively.

This affirms that family firms enjoy a distinct capacity to orchestrate resources dynamically in response to changing conditions that affect innovation processes (Sharma & Salvato, 2011). Therefore, family governance can result in the development of unique resources (Habbershon, Williams, & MacMillan, 2003) that the family firm may leverage in ways that influence innovation processes and outcomes (Chrisman et al., 2015). The pursuit of noneconomic goals in family firms determines their attitude towards risk, especially performance risk (Gomez-Mejía et al., 2007), which may shape innovation decisions (Meroño-Cerdán, López-Nicolás, & Molina-Castillo, 2018). Building on the work of De Massis et al. (2014), Chrisman et al. (2015) proposed a framework for organising the influence of family involvement on innovation management. According to this framework, family firms enjoy a greater ability to innovate precisely because of the high level of control that characterises family governance. However, at the same time, the value placed on noneconomic goals explains the willingness of family owners to develop idiosyncratic behaviours in making innovation decisions (Meroño-Cerdán, López-Nicolás, & Molina-Castillo, 2018). In fact, the aforementioned studies reveal a particular decision-making paradigm of innovation based on SEW tenets, risk preferences for innovation decisions (Nieto, Santamaria, & Fernandez, 2015) and the desire to maintain control over the firm (Duran et al., 2015).

Founder and generation in the family firm and innovation

Decision-making in first-generation family firms is more centralised than in later-generation family firms (Dyer, 1988) and demands managers' full dedication. As a result, two potentially adverse scenarios can occur with the founder at the helm of a family firm (Eddleston

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et al., 2013): The first-generation firm may assume excessive risk under the centralised power of the founder, or the firm may become overly cautious in an effort to protect the wealth of the family (Casillas, Moreno, & Barbero, 2010).

The relevance of the generational stage as it relates to innovation decisions in family firms is gaining increasing research interest (Calabro et al., 2019), especially considering that generational involvement is among the most distinctive ways through which family dynamics influence company decisions and outcomes (Pittino et al., 2020). Cesaroni, Chamochumbi Diaz, & Sentuti (2021) review literature on this topic and find empirical evidence to support a higher level of innovation in first-generation family firms, as well as studies pointing out that succession can increase family firm's inclination to innovate. In family firms that aspire to be transgenerational, innovation enhances their ability to be entrepreneurial over the long run (Diaz-Moriana et al., 2020).

A founder's concentration of roles (i.e., owner, manager and head of the family) affects the relationship between family and business objectives and, in turn, their behaviour according to the SEW approach. Table 1 shows some relevant studies covering orientation to family or business objectives according to generational stage. This review aims to better understand decision-making and innovative behaviours through generations.

According to Stockmans, Lybaert, & Voordeckers (2010), founders see family objectives as more important than business objectives. Specifically, first-generation and founder-led private family firms have a greater incentive to engage in behaviours that preserve their SEW. When successive generations enter the firm, the focus shifts from family objectives to a combination of family and business objectives (Davis & Harveston, 1999; Ensley & Pearson, 2005). Accordingly, later generations place a diminishing emphases on SEW.

However, for Le Breton-Miller & Miller (2013), founders see themselves as business builders more than family patriarchs, fathers or husbands. To survive, they pursue sound business practices rather than indulging short-term family-centric whims, resolving disputes and family pressures that might hurt the business. The family-founder firm's primary objective is to obtain enough resources to ensure viability and growth (Gersick et al., 1997). Founders are entrepreneurs, which may not be the case with their descendants. In terms of innovation, Beck et al. (2011) find that innovative firms more frequently arise among first-generation than later-generation family firms. Subsequent generations face the challenge of revitalising and expanding the business they inherit while working in the shadow of the founder (Cruz & Nordqvist, 2012). Memili, Fang, & Welsh (2015b) also support a greater orientation of first-generation family firms towards business objectives and especially to innovation in publicly traded family firms. Family-owned firms with a first-generation majority are more successful than family-owned firms with a second-generation or later majority, both in terms of value creation (transforming innovation input into innovation output) and value appropriation (as innovation output drives firm performance).

TABLE 1 Literature about orientation towards family-business according to generation.

First generation family firms more family oriented	
Davis & Harveston (1999)	Sample: 1002 US family firms Period: 1994 Methodology: telephone survey - quantitative
Ensley & Pearson (2005)	Sample: 224 from Inc. 500 (group of private firms that are among the fastest-growing in the U.S) Period: 1994, 1996 and 1999. Methodology: Mail - Quantitative
Stockmans, Lybaert, & Voordeckers (2010)	Sample: 132 Flemish SME private family firms. Period: 2001 Methodology: Mail—Quantitative
First generation family firms more business oriented	
Beck et al. (2011)	Sample: 111 small- and medium-sized family businesses in Belgium and The Netherlands Period: not available Methodology: Mail—Quantitative
Cesaroni, Chamochumbi Diaz, & Sentuti (2021)	Sample: Four cases Italian family businesses Period: not available Methodology: Qualitative
Cruz & Nordqvist (2012)	Sample: 882 Spanish small- and medium-sized family businesses Period: 2005 Methodology: Phone - Quantitative
Diaz-Moriana et al. (2020)	Sample: Five cases Irish family firms Period: 2017 Methodology: Qualitative
Eddleston et al. (2013)	Sample: 107 US private family firms Period: not available Methodology: Mail -Quantitative
Memili, Fang, & Welsh (2015b)	Sample: observations of the S&P 500 firms Period: 2002 to 2006 Methodology: Quantitative

Although previous works might have addressed the study of innovation with a generation variable, this research introduces some novelties pertaining specifically to methodological issues. Most of the studies hitherto take a quantitative approach to analyse large or public family firms. The generation variable is mainly observed in terms of owners or managers in charge. This study relies on a qualitative approach to reveal how family involvement and the founder's presence or absence influence innovation decisions in small and medium family firms, enhancing conceptual and practical understanding of one of the foundational issues characterising family

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business (Fletcher, Massis, & Nordqvist, 2016). In so doing, an inductive approach will be adopted to collect further evidence in a way that allows for theory building, per Gioia, Corley, & Hamilton (2013).

A core tenet of this research is the focus on SEW heterogeneity in terms of family involvement and the founder's presence to uncover how innovation decisions are made in family firms. In this manner, some calls to consider SEW as a source of heterogeneity are answered, as in Calabro et al. (2019) or the works mentioned above by De Massis, Wang, & Chua (2019) and Rau, Schneider-Siebke, & Günther (2019). In a similar way, according to Le Breton-Miller & Miller (2013), SEW priorities are shaped by family involvement and stages of the life cycle of the family firm. The presence of the founder is also seen as a determinant of SEW orientation (Duran et al., 2015).

METHODOLOGY

A qualitative approach suits exploratory research encompassing theory building, as it focuses on *how* and *why*, rather than *what* or *how many* (Yin, 2013). This approach especially suits the study of family firms, due to the complexity they derive from the intersection of family and business systems (De Massis & Kotlar, 2014).

Multiple-case study design ranks among the most common qualitative tools in family-business research (e.g., Diaz-Moriana et al., 2020; Kotlar & De Massis, 2013; Kudlats, Money, & Hair, 2014; Overbeke, Bilimoria, & Perelli, 2013). Following the recommendations of relevant studies in the field of qualitative methods (e.g., Eisenhardt, 1989; Hillebrand, 2019; Kammerlander et al., 2015; Kammerlander & De Massis, 2020), a multiple-case study was designed to address the research questions. Comparative case studies are one common way to analyse how different characteristics lead to different outcomes, as is the case of heterogeneity (Van Burg et al., 2022). As employed in an increasing number of studies (Houghton et al., 2013; Kohlbacher, 2006), a multiple-case study research method will be adopted, based mainly on interviews for data collection, followed by content analysis through qualitative data analysis software (QDA). Employing a combination of methods has long been a pillar of social science research (Timans, Wouters, & Heilbron, 2019). Although some controversy may persist about the nature and contribution of content analysis, for this study, the method fits with the qualitative approach and helps to interpret data relating to the social world of the participants in order to support theory building.

In this study, the research questions were formulated as follows: How does family involvement influence innovation decisions? How is that relationship affected by the founder's presence or absence? Taking the generation variable into consideration in terms of the founder's presence or absence, two different aspects were explored through an open-ended interview question: *How do you think that family involvement influences (a) the operation and goals of the firm and (b) the innovation process?* Instead of inquiring directly about the effect on innovation, the scope of the study was expanded to additionally consider the wider context of the entire firm in each case.

Previous knowledge of the cases ensured that all the participants were family firms. No matter which definition of family firm was considered (e.g., family involvement in ownership and/or management and family values [Klein, Astrachan, & Smyrnios, 2005] or desire for continuity [Gomez-Mejía et al., 2007]), all firms were classified undoubtedly as family firms. In each case, both the companies' ownership and management are entirely familial, with no other owners apart from the founders or their descendants. In a similar vein, all of the firms are managed by family members. Moreover, all the firms share similar values in that they belong to Family Firms Associations and/or collaborate with the activities organised by the Chair of Family Firm.

Case selection considered mainly two criteria. First, the case's suitability for the study was analysed to assess its appropriateness for one of two groups of family firms that would differ only in the presence or absence of the founder. Previous contact and knowledge of the firm by researchers were important for the final selection. Second was the firm's accessibility for researchers to gather reliable information. In this regard, the trust derived from previous interactions was also of great value. Eventually, the number of interviews arranged with family firms rose to eight. The criteria for selecting cases included the presence of the founder, the sector of activity and the size and growth of firm revenue. In all cases where the founder was no longer present, descendants were at the forefront of the firm. Financial information was extracted from the OSIRIS database (Van Dyck Bureau of Electronic Publishing). Case information appears in Table 2, revealing the relationship between the founder's presence and performance. All cases of founder-led firms are small firms showing negative growth, implying weaker performance than that of firms whose founder is no longer present.

The number of cases aligns with previous literature. Guest, Bunce, & Johnson (2006) find that 6-to-12 interviews are appropriate, since data saturation typically occurs at ten cases. In line with this finding, Marshall et al. (2013) note that 65% of studies with a multiple-case design use eight cases or fewer. Initially, for this study, additional cases were considered. However, analysis revealed that those new cases did not introduce new codes or categories. Put differently, saturation was reached; gathering fresh data no longer sparked new theoretical insights nor revealed new properties of core theoretical categories (Charmaz, 2006). Redundancy is a signal to cease data collection (Faulkner & Trotter, 2017). The origins of saturation lie in grounded theory (Glaser & Strauss, 1967), which, in one form or

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TABLE 2 Information of cases.

Firm	Presence of founder (generation)	Sector	Revenue mil € 2013	Size	Revenue 2013/2007	Growth
A	No (2G)	Food industry	36,000	Medium	64%	+
B	No (2G)	Food industry	27,000	Medium	126%	+
C	No (3G)	Hotels	13,000	Medium	−23%	−
D	No (3G)	Food industry	2000	Medium	86%	+
E	Yes (2G)	Hotels	1000	Small	−44%	−
F	Yes (2G)	Food industry	600	Small	−48%	−
G	Yes (NG)	Firm services	400	Small	−41%	−
H	Yes (2G)	Firm services	300	Small	−19%	−

another, commands acceptance across a range of approaches to qualitative research (Saunders et al., 2018), including specifically those employing interviews as the primary data source. As Marshall et al. (2013) state, the number of interviews depends on the quality of interviews, the researchers' experience and the sample selection. In this study, the CEO of each firm constitutes the single informant, and the researcher has prior knowledge of the cases in selecting those more appropriate for the purpose. It is desirable to have a representative sample with variation in the dimensions of theoretical interest. However, given the difficulties of procuring a representative case, purposive sampling may be more appropriate on both practical and theoretical grounds (Gerring & McDermott, 2007).

After explaining to each interviewee the main components of the design phase (defining the purpose of the research and justifying the methodological approach and selection of cases), the next phase was collecting information according to the agreed protocol. The distributed questionnaire included two sets of questions. First, warm-up questions were asked in order to create an environment of trust and flexibility and procure additional information about the firm beyond that acquired from public sources of information. Specifically, research participants were asked to answer the date of the firm's foundation, the reasons for its founding and the incorporation and presence of the family in the firm. Second, research questions about the influence of family involvement on operation and innovation were asked. Interviews were conducted for an average duration of 90 min and were recorded. Later, follow-up interviews were conducted for additional clarity or to collect further information about the firm; this was the case of three of the eight firms.

As stated, interviewees were the CEOs of their family firms (belonging all of them to the family); therefore, a single-informant design was used. Following from the research questions, the CEO of a family firm can provide a sufficiently unbiased view of the firm as the unit of analysis. The use of a single-informant design can be appropriate either in quantitative studies (Krause, Luzzini, & Lawson, 2018) or in qualitative studies, such as this one. Marshall (1996) states that the key informant technique is used extensively and successfully as a qualitative research method in social science research. This kind of informant in family firms (i.e., member of the family who is responsible for management) has superior in-depth knowledge of the firm, as well as a plethora of stored archival material (e.g., firm chronicles, letters, press announcements, ads and family biographies) that allows researchers to dig into both their contemporary and historical dynamics (Kammerlander & De Massis, 2020). The CEO of a family firm should possess the requisite knowledge, role, communicability and willingness, all of which are described as the ideal characteristics for a key informant by Tremblay (1957). One of the disadvantages of the CEO is that they might not represent the view of all the individuals in the firm. However, for the cases used in this research, innovation was clearly a prominent decision for each interviewee.

The analytical tool used in this qualitative study is content analysis, which Berelson (1952) originally defined as an objective, systematic and quantitative technique. As stated previously, current approaches to content analysis are equally fit for QDA. Following a clear protocol allows for replication of the research, and the use of coding allows the research team to quantify the frequency and importance of each argument. Content analysis functions as a bridge between the languages of qualitative and quantitative research (Boyatzis, 1998) and as a method for identifying and analysing patterns in qualitative data (Braun & Clarke, 2013).

According to Krippendorff (2013), employing content analysis requires the researcher to define its elements or steps: (1) the object of analysis, (2) the rules of codification and (3) the system of categories. A computer-assisted qualitative data analysis tool, namely, MAXQDA version 12, was utilised. Such tools facilitate examining textual data, but researchers must interpret, conceptualise, examine relationships, document decisions and develop theory (Bringer, Johnston, & Brackenridge, 2004). Coding involves segmenting the data into units to facilitate insights, comparisons and the development of theory (Strauss & Corbin, 1998). Each case was analysed to

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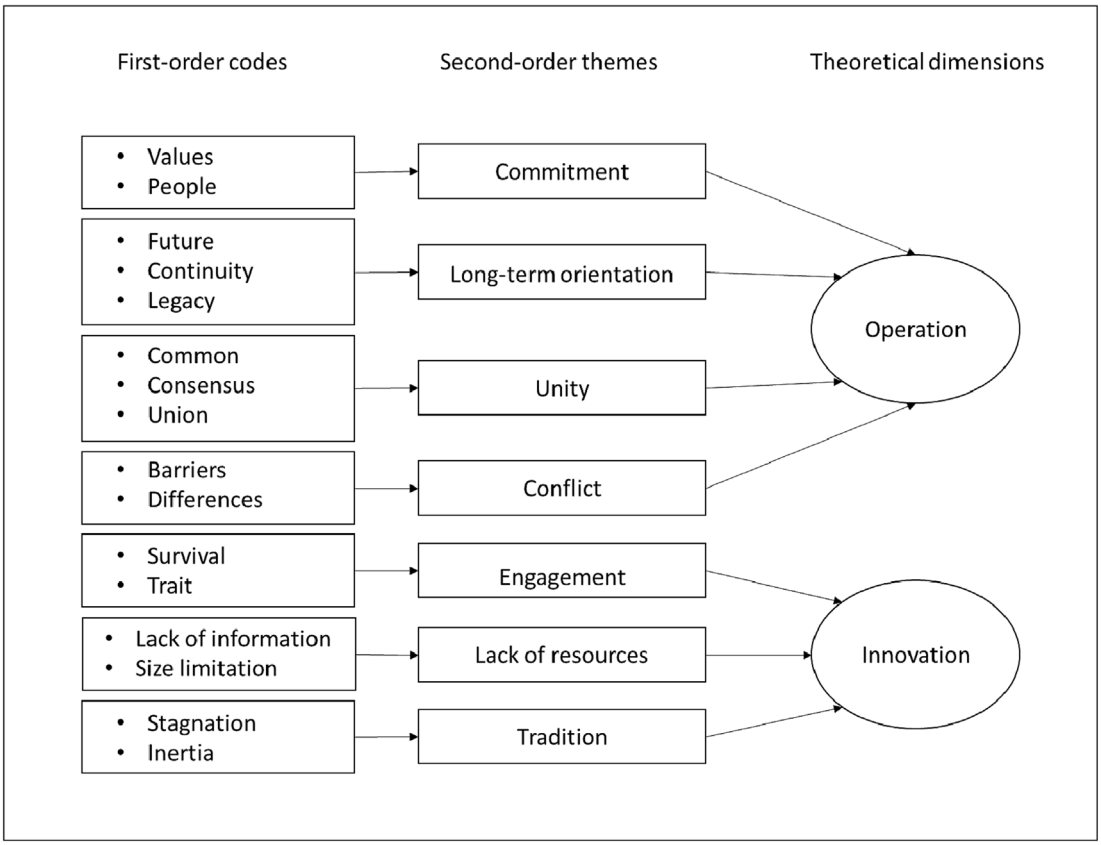

FIGURE 1 Data structure.

identify codes and then carry out a cross-case comparison.

Codification transforms the contents of the interviews into units that allow for a precise description of the influence of family involvement on innovation. The frequency of appearance of each code shows its importance. There are diverse approaches to coding. The field of family firms uses a combination of bottom-up and top-down (Kudlats, Money, & Hair, 2014) codes. Top-down codes are those that the researcher suspects to be present based on extant literature. Bottom-up codes are generated from the data. It is also common to differentiate between first-order and second-order codes (Kotlar & De Massis, 2013). Through open or bottom-up coding, first-order concepts are created. After an iterative review process, those codes are depurated and assigned to second-order themes (Gioia, Corley, & Hamilton, 2013) or categories. The literature enhances the internal validity and generalisability of the emergent codes and the corresponding second-order themes (Irava & Moores, 2010).

Following Gioia, Corley, & Hamilton's (2013) research recommendations, this study used a bottom-up approach to identify sixteen codes which were then classified into seven second-order themes for each theoretical dimension. Considering fundamental contributions coming from the literature review, coding process went back and forth taking into account data and literature as recommended by Tomo et al. (2022). Two coders verified the final codes with an 85% rate of agreement (inter-rater reliability using Cohen's Kappa coefficient), surpassing the 70% threshold (Boyatzis, 1998). The resulting data structure is presented in Figure 1.

FINDINGS

Family influence on operation and goals

Table 3 shows the codification results and some quoted excerpts from interviews regarding the influence of the family on firm operation. Additional information related to the type of family firm, according to the founder's presence, appears with each quote. As mentioned, codes are assigned to second-order themes proposed by the researcher.

Interviewees' answers reflect a globally positive view of family involvement. The most frequent second-order theme is 'commitment', followed by 'long-term vision' and 'unity'. In last place is 'conflict', the only negative theme. Each code is addressed in terms of quotes and the relationship with theoretical concepts within the domain of the 'family firm'.

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TABLE 3 Codes and quotes related to operation.

Second-order themes	First-order codes	Quotes	F	Post-F
Commitment (75%)	Values	'We had always tried to build a culture of family firm emphasizing values as the owner's commitment and responsibility'. (Case B)		●
		'We inherited a firm culture with commitment as main value, commitment with the firm, commitment with the family name and values'. (Case C)		●
		'My father's traits and behaviours both inside the firm and the family are of great influence; his dedication and honesty are values present in the firm'. (Case H)	●	
		'There are some inherent values in family firms like respect, tolerance, pride, dialogue …'. (Case D)		●
	People	'We try to work as a clan with a favourable climate to develop direct and personal interrelationship among workers and owners'. (Case G)	●	
		'When making decisions numbers are important but also feelings … it is really hard to dismiss someone because of the knowledge of the employee even of their families'. (Case E)	●	
Long-term orientation (62.5%)	Future	'Our goal is to create a business project that guarantees the present and gain the future'. (Case B)		●
	Continuity	'Among the objectives of our firm, we try to preserve the firm's continuity'. (Case A)		●
		'Emotional side encourages to continue'. (Case C)		●
		'It is already solved who continues with the firm'. (Case G)	●	
	Legacy	'My starting point is a legacy which fosters us to more ambitious objectives'. (Case D)		●
Unity (37.5%)	Common	'Our parents instilled us to work for a common good instead than for individual goals'. (Case F)	●	
	Consensus	'Decisions are taken in common looking for consensus'. (Case E)	●	
	Union	'There is a total union, in the firm family issues are discussed and vice versa'. (Case H)	●	
Conflict (25%)	Barriers	'Sometimes the family may be a barrier because of the different point of views crash'. (Case F)	●	
	Differences	'Each family branch does not have the same education nor do they have the same vision, not even inside each branch … this makes more complex the decision-making'. (Case A)		●

Note: F = Founder; post-F = Post-founder (absence of founder).

Commitment

Asked to explain family influence on the firm, CEOs mostly related (75%) themes of commitment. The codes labelled within the second-order theme 'commitment' mainly constitute references to values and people. Commitment to values seems to have greater importance in firms where the founder is no longer present. These values include building a culture consistent with the owner's responsibility (Case B); commitment to family name and values (Case C); influences of the founder's behaviour, such as honesty and dedication (Case H); and such values as respect, tolerance and dialogue (Case D). In cases with the founder in charge, the commitment is largely to people: work is seen a clan that develops personal interrelationships among workers and owners (Case G) the feelings of employees are granted importance in decision-making (Case E).

Long-term orientation

Long-term orientation (i.e., the transgenerational vision) is the second notion frequently cited as part of the influence of family involvement. The codes under this second-order theme mainly concern the future (Case B), continuity as preservation of the firm (Case A), the emotional impulse to continue (Case C) and the founder's legacy as a starting point for pursuing ambitious objectives (Case D) (Table 3). Overall, in almost all the cases, references to long-term orientation are drawn from firms where the founder is not present.

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TABLE 4 Codes and quotes related to innovation.

Second-order themes	First-order codes	Quotes	F	Post-F
Engagement (50%)	Survival	'Benefits are reinvested to keep on improving. Our goal is to assure business continuity; therefore, we are constantly changing to get ahead'. (Case E)	●	
	Trait	'Our values lead us to innovation'. (Case D)		●
		'Innovation is the main trait of family firms'. (Case C)		●
		'Engagement with the firm. Money is only a tool to keep on improving'. (Case B)		●
Lack of resources (25%)	Lack of Information	'The day-to-day operations do not allow us to look for information'. (Case F)	●	
	Size limitation	'We cannot access the same resources as large firms do'. (Case E)	●	
Tradition (25%)	Stagnation	'Death of family firms is to be stagnant'. (Case F)	●	
	Inertia	'It is difficult to innovate when the previous generation is working 30 years in their own way'. (Case H)	●	

Note: F = Founder; post-F = Postfounder (absence of founder).

Unity

Codes classified under the second-order theme of 'Unity' refer to the common good instead of individual goals (Case F), consensus in decision-making (Case E) and the union of family and firm (Case H) (Table 3). All these codes appear in firms with the founder in charge.

Conflict

Conflicts increase the complexity of decision-making in family firms. Conflict ranges from family as a source of differences (Case A) to the creation of barriers due to internal hostilities (Case F). Therefore, differences and barriers are the codes assigned to the second-order theme of 'conflict' (Table 3).

Family influence on innovation

The CEOs' answers reflect the dual perception of innovation in family firms. Half of the interviewees consider family engagement positively, while one out of four sees a negative influence, due to the weight of tradition, and the same proportion associates the family firm with a lack of resources.

Next, we address the identified codes and second-order themes (Table 4).

Engagement

The second-order theme 'engagement' encompasses the codes 'survival' (that is, changing to get ahead, as in Case E) and a 'basic trait of family firms' (Cases B, C and D) (Table 4).

TABLE 5 Second-order theme and code's frequency by the presence of the founder.

		Founder	
		Yes	No
Operation	[75%] Commitment	50%	50%
	[67%] Values	25%	75%
	[33%] People	100%	0%
	[62.5%] Long-term	20%	80%
	[20%] Future	0%	100%
	[60%] Continuity	33%	67%
	[20%] Legacy	0%	100%
	[37.5%] Unity	100%	0%
	[33%] Common	100%	0%
	[33%] Consensus	100%	0%
	[33%] Union	100%	0%
	[25%] Conflict	50%	50%
	[50%] Barriers	100%	0%
	[50%] Differences	0%	100%
Innovation	[50%] Engagement	25%	75%
	[25%] Survival	100%	0%
	[75%] Trait	0%	100%
	[25%] Lack of resources	100%	0%
	[50%] Lack of info	100%	0%
	[50%] Size limitations	100%	0%
	[25%] Tradition	1000%	0%
	[50%] Stagnation	100%	0%
	[50%] Inertia	100%	0%

Lack of resources; tradition

The second-order theme 'Lack of resources' is linked to misinformation (Case F) and small firm size (Case E).

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Tradition reflects stagnation (Case F) and inertia (Case H) (Table 4).

Generation

Next, results were analysed according to the presence of the founder (Table 5). Commitment is truly important and was present in 75% of the total mentions in the study's eight cases. In 67% of the quotes from interviewees, commitment pertains to values; the remaining percentage associates commitment with people. Although no differences appeared to arise from the presence of the founder (there was a 50% frequency in founder firms as well as 50% in post-founder firms), the analysis of the codes reveals a stronger orientation towards people in founder firms (100%). Post-founder firms are more values-oriented (75%). Long-term orientation predominates in post-founder firms, especially regarding concern for the future and legacy. Meanwhile, unity is a concern only for founder firms. In the case of conflict, the barriers that derive from conflict limit founder firms, while post-founder firms regard conflict as the existence of differences that must be faced by the firm. In the sphere of innovation, the lack of resources and the weight of tradition limit founder firms; post-founder firms engage more with innovation. In the only case of a founder firm concerned with innovation, it was related to the means of survival.

TABLE 6 Cross-case comparison.

		Not founder				Founder			
Second-order themes	Codes	Case A	Case B	Case C	Case D	Case E	Case F	Case G	Case H
Commitment (75%)	Values		✓	✓	✓				✓
	People					✓		✓	
Long-term orientation (62.5%)	Future		✓						
	Continuity	✓		✓				✓	
	Legacy				✓				
Unity (37.5%)	Common						✓		
	Consensus					✓			
	Union								✓
Conflict (25%)	Barriers						✓		
	Differences	✓							
Engagement (50%)	Survival					✓			
	Trait		✓	✓	✓				
Lack of resources (25%)	Lack of Information						✓		
	Size limitation					✓			
Tradition (25%)	Stagnation						✓		
	Inertia								✓

TABLE 7 Spearman correlation.

	Unity	Conflict	Commitment	Long-term	Engagement	Neutral	Lack of resources
Unity							
Conflict	0.149						
Commitment	−0.149	−1.000***					
Long-term	−1.000***	−0.149	0.149				
Engagement	−0.258	−0.577†	0.577†	0.258			
Neutral	−0.447	0.333	−0.333	0.447	−0.577†		
Lack of resources	0.745*	0.333	−0.333	−0.745*	0.000	−0.333	
Tradition	0.745*	0.333	−0.333	−0.745*	−0.577†	−0.333	0.333

†$p < 0.1$.
*$p < 0.05$.
**$p < 0.01$.
***$p < 0.001$.

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Cross-case analysis

To obtain a clearer picture of the results, Table 6 shows a cross-case comparison considering second-order themes and codes. A visual examination reveals some interesting interrelationships. Three of the four post-founder firms (Cases B, C and D) display a close link between commitment, long-term orientation and innovation engagement. The remaining firm (Case A) shows only a long-term orientation, a natural feature of an established firm. This also reveals the existence of conflict. The personal knowledge of the researcher supports the evidence for a rivalry between the views and goals of different branches of the family, resulting in a lack of commitment and engagement. In Cases B, C and D, at the time of data collection, there was a clear and well-accepted hierarchy that strengthened decision-making. The firms with the founder still present are all small companies experiencing a decline in revenue. Three of the four companies emphasised the importance of unity, the weight of tradition, or a lack of resources as factors affecting their innovation decision; these accounted for 100% of the mentions of those codes. The only company with the founder still in the firm and that did not present any barriers to innovation or mention conflict or unity is the one whose founder is at the forefront of the firm (Case G). This company also underlined the importance of commitment and long-term orientation.

Using the information on second-order themes and cases (Table 6) to gain deeper insights, two analyses of interrelationships were performed with content analysis software: (a) a bivariate Spearman correlation analysis (Table 7) examining relationships among second-order themes and (b) a second-order theme-relations analysis (Table 8) to visualise overlapping second-order themes in terms of proximity in text. Although these tools are added values of QDA software, they have scarcely been used thus far, and only in non-scientific literature.

Figure 2 shows the main relationships among second-order themes. One clear link exists between family

TABLE 8 Proximity of codes.

Code system	Unity	Conflict	Commitment	Long-term	Engagement	Neutral	Lack of resources	Tradition
Unity	0							
Conflict	2	0						
Commitment	4	0	0					
Long-term	0	2	8	0				
Engagement	2	0	8	6	0			
Neutral	0	2	2	4	0	0		
Lack of resources	4	2	2	0	2	0	0	
Tradition	4	2	2	0	0	0	2	0

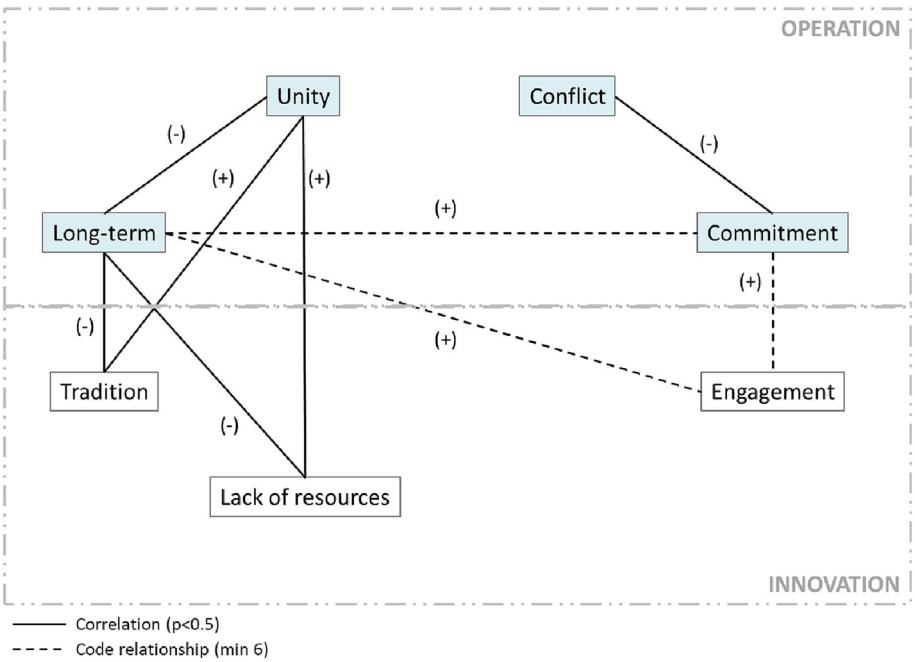

FIGURE 2 Second-order theme's relationship.

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influence on operation and innovation. Two apparent configurations seem to emerge, according to the importance of family and business dimensions.

Family-first

Although in an isolated way, unity might appear as positive, family firms where unity prevails over business matters experience the negative side of family involvement to a greater extent. Unity negatively correlates with a long-term orientation. In the sphere of innovation, unity is associated with the weight of tradition and lack of resources. In other words, under the delusion of unity, innovation may be postponed.

Business-first

The long-term focus rests on a strong feeling of commitment, which is key to overcoming family conflicts. At the same time, firms engaged in innovation are more committed and oriented towards the long-term; among them, tradition deserves less consideration.

MODELS AND PROPOSITIONS

This section presents some propositions formulated in line with other studies in the field (e.g., Hiebl, 2015; Kammerlander et al., 2015). Per De Massis & Kotlar (2014), the propositions aim to inspire future confirmatory research and increase the testability of the findings.

Unity

Although unity is a central value in the family domain, salient literature is relatively scarce in family-firm research. Eddleston, Kellermanns, & Zellweger (2012) use the term family-to-firm unity to refer to the bond a family has with the firm, embodying a sense of oneness and integration. Jaskiewicz et al. (2016) find that family unity is very closely related to family continuity; both concepts constitute part of the logic of the family. Furthermore, family unity is a determinant factor in the transmission of the firm across generations. Despite the theoretical arguments highlighting the positive effects of unity, Eddleston, Kellermanns, & Zellweger (2012) reveal that in specific scenarios, family-to-firm unity reinforces the status quo, preventing the achievement of expected benefits.

Miller, Le Breton-Miller, & Scholnick (2008) analyse the view of family firms as conservative organisations that suffer from a paucity of resources of all kinds (managerial and financial, among others). The authors introduce the term 'stagnation perspective'. Highly concentrated ownership may lead to risk aversion and strategic inertia (Naldi et al., 2007). Chirico & Nordqvist (2010) identify the paternalistic culture in some family firms as a key factor promoting family inertia. Paternalism is the practice of excessively caring for others, to the extent of interfering with their decisions and autonomy. In paternalistic cultures, decisions are often made in the realm of the family rather than in the realm of the business.

Considering the evidence gathered in this study, although unity could be expected to produce positive effects on commitment (Poza, Hanlon, & Kishida, 2004) or long-term orientation (Jaskiewicz et al., 2016), the reality is quite different. In most cases, the desire for unity prevents the firm from achieving benefits (Eddleston, Kellermanns, & Zellweger, 2012). Analysis of the cases confirms the prevalence of unified consensus over firm requirements; the subordination of business commitment to family unity hinders business survival.

Although recent analyses show tradition as a valuable resource in innovation (De Massis et al., 2016), evidence reveals tradition as equivalent to stagnation and inertia (Naldi et al., 2007) that prevent the firm from exploring innovative ideas (Zahra, Hayton, & Salvato, 2004). In sum, unity will be associated with tradition and lack of resources. Both threaten the goal of long-term orientation in family firms.

> **Proposition 1.** *Unity is associated with tradition and lack of resources to innovate and negatively associated with a long-term orientation.*

Commitment

Most research assumes that family involvement will translate into family influence, but such influence is not automatic (Zellweger, Eddleston, & Kellermanns, 2010). The essence of the family-influence approach argues that family involvement must be focused and directed towards behaviours that produce distinctiveness (Chrisman, Chua, & Sharma, 2005). That 'essence' is evaluated through two components: family commitment and the transgenerational vision (Chrisman et al., 2012). Commitment appears as a consequence of psychological ownership with which family members experiment (Mahto et al., 2010). Ramos et al. (2014) argue that the less complex and clan-like environment of small family firms can drive the expansion of psychological ownership towards the whole organisation, often resulting in special caretaking of employees. In sum, family members bring their family values, developing an intense commitment towards the firm in a broad sense.

Firms that view themselves as family firms expect the firm to remain in the family through the generations (Hoffmann, Junge, & Malchow-Møller, 2015). Family firms are loss-averse concerning their socioemotional

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wealth. However, family involvement does tend to promote risk-taking if control and socioemotional wealth are at stake (Gomez-Mejía et al., 2007). According to Chrisman et al. (2015), family firms present a greater ability to innovate, but at the same time, they place a high value on noneconomic goals, which explains the willingness of family owners to develop idiosyncratic behaviours around innovation decisions. The coincidence of ownership and management in family members allows them to be more innovative when they perceive a threat to the firm. Family managers have the authority and legitimacy to pursue the option they perceive as best (Gedajlovic, Lubatkin, & Schulze, 2004). This high level of control and the desire to preserve their wealth lead family firms to have a superior ability and willingness to monitor the innovation process and obtain higher innovation outputs (Duran et al., 2015).

Commitment and transgenerational vision are the cornerstones of the essence approach (Chrisman et al., 2012). In addition, family commitment is a driver of longevity (Astrachan, 2010). In the study cases, evidence shows the desire for continuity through commitment, especially via adhesion to values derived from family involvement in the firm. In this work, a great similarity emerges between commitment and engagement. Whereas the scope of commitment is the firm in a broad sense, the scope of engagement narrows to the sphere of innovation. Threats to the firm that put its continuity at stake trigger a willingness to innovate (Chrisman et al., 2015), producing higher innovation outputs (Duran et al., 2015).

Proposition 2. *Commitment is positively influenced by long-term orientation and innovation engagement.*

Conflict

Conflict and disagreement among family members constitute a major focus of family-firm research (Sonfield & Lussier, 2004). Eddleston, Kellermanns, & Sarathy (2008) suggest that the achievement of competitive advantages due to family ties depends on the ability to monitor family conflict. Two kinds of conflict require consideration: affective and cognitive conflict. Although cognitive conflict might lead to better decisions, some studies find a negative relationship between both forms of conflict, even in the field of family firms (e.g., Kellermanns & Eddleston, 2007). This can possibly be attributed to the ease with which cognitive conflict can transition into affective conflict. Theoretical reasoning by Webb, Ketchen, & Ireland (2010) places family firms in a position where the risks of both kinds of conflicts would decrease. Largely due to high levels of trust, tasks disagreements are less likely to be misinterpreted as personal attacks. At the same time, the dominating presence of the family in management would tend to decrease cognitive conflict because the family members share values and goals. Nonetheless, the authors find that family firms do avoid the negative implications of affective conflict but fail to accrue the functional benefits of cognitive conflict.

Cognitive conflict would predictably play a positive role in family firms (Webb, Ketchen, & Ireland, 2010); nevertheless, studies find it has a negative relationship with decision outcomes (Kellermanns & Eddleston, 2007). Case evidence indicates that conflicts have negative effects, acting as barriers to decision-making or simply increasing the complexity and the need to negotiate that can stymie one's ability to make the best decision. Specifically, the results show that concern about unity has no effect on the level of conflict. Incidentally, a negative relationship is detected between conflict on one hand and, on the other hand, commitment and innovation engagement. In other words, conflict declines as a result not of unity but of a higher commitment.

Proposition 3. *Conflict is independent of unity and negatively associated with commitment and innovation engagement.*

Founder

Further insights result from considering the distribution of second-order themes according to the founder's presence (Tables 3 and 4). Commitment appears to be more people-oriented when the founder is at the forefront, whereas the predominance of other values defines commitment in post-founder firms. Moreover, conflict varies; different points of view often block decisions when the founder is active. However, second and later generations still face conflict; although disagreement exists, previously developed rules or practices drive decision-making.

When the founder is active, unity prevails, commitment is to people rather than to the firm, decisions are postponed to avoid conflict and innovation is conditioned by suffering a lack of resources. SEW acts as an impediment, even when the business is at risk. In light of the case descriptions, founder firms are found to be smaller and show worse performance. In comparison, post-founder firms regard innovation as essential to survival. Awareness of differences helps to build a culture that encourages business sustainability. For these cases, SEW acts as a catalyst, aligning goals for business continuity with those of the family.

The aforementioned innovation patterns can be linked to a founder effect, giving rise to the proposal of two additional propositions.

Proposition 4. *When the founder is at the head of the firm, overvaluing unity may endanger business continuity, given that tradition may harm innovation engagement.*

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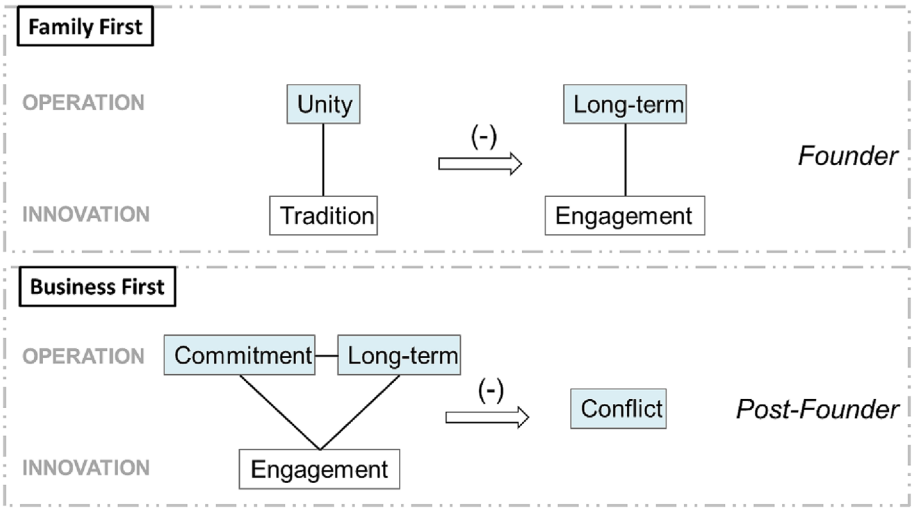

FIGURE 3 Innovation patterns and founder presence.

> **Proposition 5.** *Post-founder firms find firm commitment to be the cornerstone that assures business continuity through engagement with innovation. This approach also reduces conflict.*

Figure 3 summarises findings of this study and the set of propositions formulated to contribute to future research. Two innovation patterns have been identified, each being associated with the presence or absence of the firm founder. In the family-first pattern, unity, tradition and lack of resources are negatively associated with the long-term orientation (Proposition 1) scenario more frequent in founder firms (Proposition 4). The business-first pattern is characterised by the relationship between long-term orientation and commitment-engagement (Proposition 2), which in turn decreases conflict (Proposition 3) in the scenario most common among post-founder firms (Proposition 5).

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSIONS

In this study, two innovation patterns are established, according to the importance of family and business decisions in family firms. 'Family-first' is characterised by unity prevailing over business matters. Under the delusion of unity, innovation is put aside. 'Business-first' relies on a strong feeling of commitment encouraging innovation and long-term orientation.

As expected, generation plays a central role in understanding innovation in family firms as an element of SEW heterogeneity (Stockmans, Lybaert, & Voordeckers, 2010). Current work sheds light on the debate about the priorities of firms led by founders and their attitudes towards innovation. Based on the predominant view of founders as entrepreneurs and innovators committed to the growth of the firm (Beck et al., 2011; Cesaroni, Chamochumbi Diaz, & Sentuti, 2021; Gersick et al., 1997; Le Breton-Miller & Miller, 2013; Memili, Fang, Chrisman et al., 2015a), in the first stages of the firm, the founder who struggles to take the business forward should adopt a business-first approach. However, case analysis of firms led by their founders reveals weaker performance than those in which the founder is no longer present, and yet they are more family-oriented than business-oriented to protect the family socioemotional wealth. This result reveals that inclination towards family unity in founder firms makes them more conservative (Miller, Le Breton-Miller, & Scholnick, 2008), risk-averse (Naldi et al., 2007) and paternalistic (Chirico & Nordqvist, 2010), which constrains innovation (Zahra, Hayton, & Salvato, 2004) and performance (Eddleston, Kellermanns, & Zellweger, 2012).

Even when the risk of failure exists, family myopia may condition firm continuity. This finding relates to the term horizon and the myopic loss aversion that Chrisman & Patel (2012) propose, wherein family firms with a short-term horizon innovate less, even when business performance falls below aspirations. The prevalence of unity may result in the sacrifice of the firm for the sake of family relations. In this sense, the founder factor challenges the tenets of SEW. In the 'business-first' approach, which is linked to post-founder family firms, SEW is confirmed to be a catalyst enabling business development through commitment and a long-term orientation. Diaz-Moriana et al. (2020) reach similar conclusions, indicating that long-term orientation shapes specific innovative behaviours in multigenerational family firms.

Gomez-Mejia, Patel, & Zellweger (2015) refine the use of reference points to analyse the alignment of family and business orientations, introducing the role of SEW as a catalyst or an impediment. Theoretically, the first stages of the firm would fit a situation of vulnerability in which performance falls below aspirations. In this case, innovation is essential to survival, family interest should be conditioned upon business interest, and SEW should act as a catalyst. Yet the results show the reverse: SEW is

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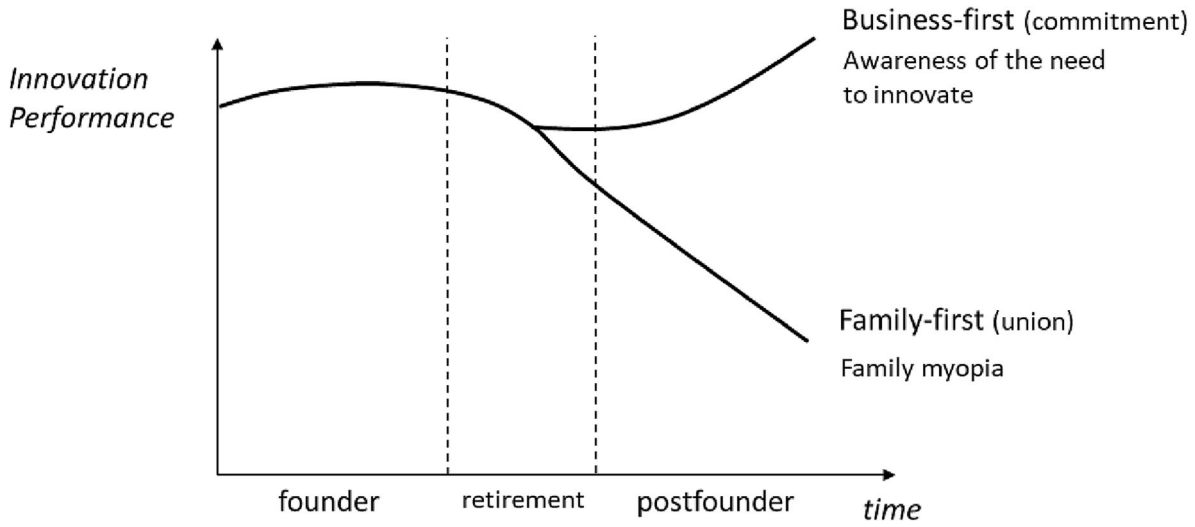

FIGURE 4 Innovation patterns according to business lifecycle and prevalence of business or family dimensions.

an impediment, in that it threatens business survival. Thus, generation—in terms of the founder's presence or absence—refines the moderating role of SEW in on innovation.

One possible interpretation of this result appears in Figure 4, showing a suggested evolution of innovation and, therefore, performance, according to the orientation towards the family and the firm. In the first stages of the family firm, the founder centralizes decision-making, and the main concern is the consolidation of the firm. Over time, the founder begins a process of retirement from the firm's forefront. In this situation, the firm normally becomes more conservative; family issues gain increasing importance and visibility. According to SEW postulates, the family firm could face a vulnerability situation, where innovation would be the answer to preserving its continuity. The results of this study calls firms that behave in this way 'business-first', referring to their commitment; these are predominantly found among post-founder firms. Nonetheless, those firms conforming to the 'family-first' pattern would act differently than SEW predicts. Despite being in a vulnerable situation, they sacrifice business continuity to maintain family unity. Usually, these firms are in the last stage of the founder's presence in the firm, characterised by a more short-term orientation and a higher likelihood of disappearing.

In other words, generation is a heterogeneity factor that improves the understanding of innovation grounded on the SEW approach. To date, few studies have addressed this topic. Memili, Fang, & Welsh (2015b) finds that first-generation family firms to be more innovative; this is based on the SEW approach and mainly due to better knowledge management. However, the population of firms is significantly different, since the authors analyse public family firms with a quantitative approach. Adopting a qualitative perspective, Diaz-Moriana et al. (2020) examine innovation under the SEW lens in a different type of family firm. These firms are not SMEs, and there is no distinction between founder and post-founder family firms. According to the results of this study, for first-generation family firms characterised as SMEs with poor performance, the preservation of SEW may act as an impediment constraining innovation and continuity, especially at the moment of the founder's retirement. Overvaluing unity leads firms to disregard business challenges and only focus on short-term needs in a phenomenon that this study terms 'family myopia'.

Among governance conditions listed as sources of heterogeneity, participation of later generations (Pittino et al., 2018) is found to play a significant role in explaining innovative behaviours in family firms. Using a qualitative approach is valuable in reconciling existing findings from quantitative studies (Fletcher, Massis, & Nordqvist, 2016). In this study, founder's influence on innovation depends on the stage. While the first years of any business demand a business-first pattern, once the founder has consolidated the firm and family members are incorporated, the lack of a unified vision may result in paying more attention to family matters than business needs.

Moreover, the results of this study align with the ability-willingness framework (Chrisman et al., 2015; De Massis et al., 2014). All the family firms evaluated in this study possess the ability to produce family-oriented particularistic behaviour. In other words, family involvement provides the chance to use a set of distinctive resources and capabilities, but the way they are used depends on the family's willingness or the way the family sees the firm. This is especially true when the founder manages the firm, since their goals, governance structure and resources may produce idiosyncratic behaviours that extend beyond economic logic. The positive traits associated with willingness—transgenerational succession, family commitment to the business and preservation of SEW

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(De Massis et al., 2014)—are present in the results of this study. However, at the same time, if family myopia is present, the business project will likely be mismanaged. In that case, the effect of family involvement would be clearly negative and would act as an impediment to business success.

Finally, there is a connection between innovation and absorptive capacity, which helps to understand the role of founders in incorporating external knowledge into their family firms. Cohen & Levinthal (1990) define absorptive capacity (AC) as a firm's ability to acquire, assimilate, transform and exploit new knowledge. AC is a dynamic capability due to the importance of properly managing new external knowledge; this largely depends on the manager's cognitive processes. Scanning external knowledge and using acquired knowledge are products of the top managers' existing knowledge and beliefs (Nag & Gioia, 2012). There is a substantial heterogeneity among firms with regard to their willingness and ability to foster AC, depending on their emotional attachment and on how they exert their power. Kotlar et al. (2020) address the paradoxical effects of family ownership on AC. The role of situational factors is crucial for understanding the heterogeneous behaviour of family firms. Among those specific to family firms, the number of generations can help in understanding the results of this current study. Founders develop a sense of harmony and cohesion that diminishes with subsequent generations, because they come to rely more on support from the external environment (Pittino & Visintin, 2011). Consequently, the ability/willingness to engage in collaborative innovation projects should increase in family firms led by the second generation and beyond.

Several lessons emerge as practical implications from this analysis. The results reveal two ways of matching family interests with firm demands: unity or commitment. Both bring about diametrically opposed consequences. Commitment is the way towards survival and continuity and helps founders minimise conflict. However, family myopia, or the delusion of unity, may provoke mismanagement, putting the business project and, consequently, the family socioemotional and financial wealth at risk. For entrepreneurs, family may be a constraint if the family dimension is not adequately managed. As the number of generations increases, so does the risk of intrafamily conflict (Davis & Harveston, 1999; Ensley & Pearson, 2005; Schulze, Lubatkin, & Dino, 2003). Clearly, coping with varying interests requires formal governance mechanisms (Eddleston et al., 2013) and family commitment as important drivers of longevity (Astrachan, 2010).

Family may be a burden (impediment) or a driver (catalyst) with regard to the business dimension. In first-generation family firms, founders should be aware of the risks of mismanaging family issues that threaten business continuity. Two particular aspects should be considered: first, the need to develop family commitment not with people but with values; second, the need to manage conflicts similarly. Simply ignoring them does not cause conflicts to disappear; indeed, it allows conflict to fester. Successful family firms oriented towards the long term have developed governance mechanisms and a culture that aligns family and business needs. In this regard, Cesaroni, Chamochumbi Diaz, & Sentuti's (2021) recommendation to consider how innovation capacities pass through generations is especially useful. Ultimately, those dynamics depend on founders' and successors' approaches towards innovation.

Regarding the limits of this research, although qualitative studies are increasing in number, there is no single standard guiding researchers to conduct qualitative research (Gioia, Corley, & Hamilton, 2013; Hannah & Lautsch, 2011; Van Burg et al., 2022). The methodological decisions made in this research study were mainly based on the research questions. Consequently, a purposive sample was created. The selection and number of cases were determined through consideration of the founder's presence. CEOs of family firms were justified as key informants to be interviewed. Content analysis was used to find patterns and create the proposed theoretical models. According to Hannah & Lautsch (2011), the use of content analysis can produce increasingly more valid arguments. To increase validity, this study performed analyses of second-order themes and interrelationships. These results should be considered to complement the cross-case analysis, the interpretation of which must be aligned to the research question and the context of the investigation. The researcher's prior knowledge of the cases proved valuable, in line with the recommendations of Elo et al. (2014); however, a more formal approach to information sources would improve objectivity.

Content analysis facilitates the identification of patterns that can explain the effect of family involvement on the firm in general, and on innovation in particular, including the founder's influence. These relationships of family and innovation, and the moderating role of the generation value, must be developed and confirmed with a larger sample and either a quantitative or a qualitative approach. In the latter, although CEOs as single informants provide valuable information about family firms, the use of multiple informants might be useful, especially in confronting the views of family members from different generations.

Potential avenues for future inquiry might address the following directions. First, future studies could extend the approach to other countries or cultural settings and thereby analyse the transferability of the results. Second, future studies could refine the concept of the founder's presence or absence, specifying the stage of the firm (e.g., first years, development, maturity, 'passing the baton'). Third, future studies could explore more deeply the link between unity and commitment. Apparently, the distance between these concepts is narrow—the development of a strong feeling of commitment requires a unified

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vision—but the effects are extremely different. The desire to preserve family relations over business goals differentiates unity from commitment. Finally, absorptive capacity is introduced as a dynamic capability closely related to family ownership and management and the ability-willingness approach.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

As the only author of this work I have no conflicts of interest to disclose.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

The data that support the findings of this study are available on request from the corresponding author. The data are not publicly available due to privacy or ethical restrictions.

ORCID

Angel L. Meroño-Cerdán https://orcid.org/0000-0002-6270-2409

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